

SOME OF THE best examples of smart financial behavior can be found in an unlikely place: Las Vegas casinos.

Not among all players, of course. But a tiny group of blackjack players who practice card counting can teach ordinary people something extraordinarily important about managing money: the importance of room for error.

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The fundamentals of blackjack card counting are simple:

- No one can know with certainty what card the dealer will draw next.
- But by tracking what cards have already been dealt you can calculate what cards remain in the deck.
- Doing so can tell you *the odds* of a particular card being drawn by the dealer.

As a player, you bet more when the odds of getting a card you want are in your favor and less when they are against you.

The mechanics of how this is done don't matter here. What matters is that a blackjack card counter knows they are playing a game of odds, not certainties. In any particular hand they think they have a good chance of being right, but know there's a decent chance they're wrong. It might sound strange given their profession, but their strategy relies entirely on humility—humility that they don't know, and cannot know exactly what's going to happen next, so play their hand accordingly. The card counting system works because it tilts the odds ever so slightly from the house to the player. But bet too heavily even when the odds seem in your favor and, if you're wrong, you might lose so much that you don't have enough money to keep playing.

There is never a moment when you're so right that you can bet every chip in front of you. The world isn't that kind to anyone—not consistently, anyways. You have to give yourself room for error. You have to plan on your plan not going according to plan.